AUTHOR'S NOTE

This book is not just an account of the ISRO spy case in which I was an accused. The case that broke out in the late 1994 as a potboiler of sex, spies and rocket science before dying down as a police misadventure that eventually fed an international conspiracy, however, forms the fulcrum of this book.

The spy case became such a defining incident that everything that happened in my life and in the development of India's space programme so far falls into either of the two periods: Before Spy Case and After Spy Case.

When the Kerala Police arrested me on November 30, 1994, I was 53. India's space programme, put to shape by Vikram Sarabhai as the Indian National Committee for Space Research (INCOSPAR) in 1962, was 31.

I, having taken over as the cryogenic project director and in the process of getting the technology from Russia, was scaling a peak of my career. The Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), which had just registered the nation's first successful launch of a Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV) only the previous month, was at the cusp of a great leap in space.

This book seeks to tell you how an 'incident' involving an allegedly amorous police inspector's attempt to corner a Maldivian woman soon snowballed into an espionage case; how a faction in the Congress party used it to bring down a government; and how India's Intelligence Bureau (IB) played into some foreign hands to halt India's march in space.

As time proved, the grand design failed. The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) exonerated all the six accused and found the case to be 'false.' The premier investigating agency went to the extent of sending confidential reports to the Government of India and the Government of